

this D'Artagnan rose, and instantly set off on the search, telling Planchet not to expect him to breakfast, and perhaps not to dinner. A day and a half spent in rummaging amongst certain dens of Paris sufficed for his recruiting; and, without allowing his adventurers to communicate with each other, he had picked up and got together, in less than thirty hours, a charming collection of ill-looking faces, speaking a French less pure than the English they were about to attempt. These men were, for the most part, guards, whose merit D'Artagnan had had an opportunity of appreciating in various encounters, whom drunkenness, unlucky sword-thrusts, unexpected winnings at play, or the economical reforms of Mazarin, had forced to seek shade and solitude, those two great consolers of irritated and chafing spirits. They bore upon their countenances and in their vestments the traces of the heartaches they had undergone. Some had their visages scared,—all had their clothes in rags. D'Artagnan comforted the most needy of these brotherly miseries by a prudent distribution of the crowns of the company; then, having taken care that these crowns should be employed in the physical improvement of the troop, he appointed a trying place in the north of France, between Bergues and Saint Omer. Six days were allowed as the utmost term, and D'Artagnan was sufficiently acquainted with the good-will, the good-humour, and the relative probity of these illustrious recruits, to be certain that not one of them would fail in his appointment. These orders given, this rendezvous fixed, he went to bid farewell to Planchet, who asked news of his army. D'Artagnan did not think it proper to inform him of the reduction he had made in his personnel. He feared that the confidence of his associate would be abated by such an avowal. Planchet was delighted to learn that the army was levied, and that he (Planchet) found himself a kind of half king, who from his throne-counter kept in pay a body of troops destined to make war against perfidious Albion, that enemy of all true French hearts. Planchet paid down in double louis, twenty thousand livres to D'Artagnan, on the part of himself (Planchet), and twenty thousand livres, still in double louis, in account with D'Artagnan. D'Artagnan placed each of the twenty thousand francs in a bag, and weighing a bag in each hand,—‘This money is very embarrassing, my dear Planchet,’ said he. ‘Do you know this weighs thirty pounds?’

‘Bah! your horse will carry that like a feather.’

D'Artagnan shook his head. ‘Don't tell me such things, Planchet: a horse overloaded with thirty pounds, in addition to the rider and his portmanteau, cannot cross a river so easily—cannot leap over a wall or ditch so lightly; and the horse failing, the horseman fails. It is true that you, Planchet, who have served in the infantry, may not be aware of all that.’

‘Then what is to be done, monsieur?’ said Planchet, greatly embarrassed.

‘Listen to me,’ said D'Artagnan. ‘I will pay my army on its return home. Keep my half of twenty thousand livres, which you can use during that time.’

‘And my half?’ said Planchet.

‘I shall take that with me.’

‘Your confidence does me honour,’ said Planchet: ‘but supposing you should not return?’

‘That is possible, though not very probable. Then, Planchet, in case I should not return—give me a pen; I will make my will.’ D'Artagnan took a pen and some paper, and wrote upon a plain sheet,—

I, D'Artagnan, possess twenty thousand livres, laid up cent per cent during thirty years that I have been in the service of his majesty the king of France. I leave five thousand to Athos, five thousand to Porthos, and five thousand to Aramis, that they may give the said sums in my name and their own to my young friend Raoul, Vicomte de Bragelonne. I give the remaining five thousand to Planchet, that he may distribute the fifteen thousand with less regret among my friends. With which purpose I sign these presents.

D'ARTAGNAN.

Planchet appeared very curious to know what D'Artagnan had written. ‘Here,’ said the musketeer, ‘read it.’

On reading the last lines the tears came into Planchet's eyes. ‘You think, then, that I would not have given the money without that? Then I will have none of your five thousand francs.’

D'Aragnan smiled. 'Accept it, accept it, Planchet; and in that way you will only lose fifteen thousand francs instead of twenty thousand, and you will not be tempted to disregard the signature of your master and friend, by losing nothing at all.'

How well that dear Monsieur d'Aragnan knew the hearts of men and grocers! They who have pronounced Don Quixote mad because he rode out to the conquest of an empire with nobody but Sancho his squire, and they who have pronounced Sancho mad because he accompanied his master in his attempt to conquer the said empire,—they certainly will have no hesitation in extending the same judgment to D'Aragnan and Planchet. And yet the first passed for one of the most subtle spirits among the astute spirits of the court of France. As to the second, he had acquired by good right the reputation of having one of the longest heads among the grocers of the Rue des Lombards; consequently of Paris, and consequently of France. Now, to consider these two men from the point of view from which you would consider other men, and the means by the aid of which they contemplated to restore a monarch to his throne, compared with other means, the shallowest brains of the country where brains are most shallow must have revolted against the presumptuous madness of the lieutenant and the stupidity of his associate. Fortunately, D'Aragnan was not a man to listen to the idle talk of those around him, or to the comments that were made on himself. He had adopted the motto, 'Act well, and let people talk.' Planchet, on his part had adopted this, 'Act and say nothing.' It resulted from this, that, according to the custom of all superior geniuses, these two men flattered themselves, *intra pectus*, with being in the right against all who found fault with them.

As a beginning, D'Aragnan set out in the finest of possible weather, without a cloud in the heavens—without a cloud on his mind, joyous and strong, calm and decided, great in his resolution, and consequently carrying with him a tenfold dose of that potent fluid which the shocks of mind cause to spring from the nerves, and which procure for the human machine a force and an influence of which future ages will render, according to all probability, a more arithmetical account than we can possibly do at present. He was again, as in times past, on that same road of adventures which had led him to Boulogne, and which he was now travelling for the fourth time. It appeared to him that he could almost recognize the trace of his own steps upon the road, and that

no fractions; I cannot divide my troop in two, and act upon two points, at once, without another self, who—But what is the use of acting upon two points, as we have only one man to take? What can be the use of weakening a corps by placing the right here, and the left there? A single corps—Mordieux! a single one, and that commanded by D'Aragnan. Very well. But twenty men marching in one band are suspected by everybody; twenty horsemen must not be seen marching together, or a company will be detached against them and the password will be required; the which company, upon seeing them embarrassed to give it, would shoot M. d'Aragnan and his men like so many rabbits. I reduce myself then to ten men; in this fashion I shall act simply and with unity; I shall be forced to be prudent, which is half the success in an affair of the kind I am undertaking; a greater number might, perhaps, have drawn me into some folly. Ten horses are not many, either, to buy or take. A capital idea; what tranquillity it infuses into my mind! no more suspicions—no passwords—no more dangers! Ten men, they are valets or clerks. Ten men, leading ten horses laden with merchandise of whatever kind, are tolerated, well received everywhere. Ten men travel on account of the house of Planchet & Co., of France,—nothing can be said against that. These ten men, clothed like manufacturers, have a good cutlass or a good musket at their saddle-bow, and a good pistol in the holster. They never allow themselves to be uneasy, because they have no evil designs. They are, perhaps, in truth, a little disposed to be smugglers, but what harm is in that? Smuggling is not, like polygamy, a hanging offence. The worst that can happen to us is the confiscation of our merchandise. Our merchandise confiscated—a fine affair that! Come, come! it is a superb plan. Ten men only—ten men, whom I will engage for my service; ten men who shall be as resolute as forty, who would cost me four times as much, and to whom, for greater security, I will never open my mouth as to my designs, and to whom I shall only say "My friends, there is a blow to be struck." Things being after this fashion, Satan will be very malicious if he plays me one of his tricks. Fifteen thousand livres saved—that's superb—out of twenty?

Thus fortified by his labourious calculations, D'Aragnan stopped at this plan, and determined to change nothing in it. He had already on a list furnished by his inexhaustible memory, ten men illustrious amongst the seekers of adventure, ill-treated by fortune, and not on good terms with justice. Upon

place, my chance is better with thirty men than forty. Besides, I should save five thousand francs; that is to say, the eighth of my capital; that is worth the trial. This being so, I should have thirty men. I shall divide them into three bands,—we will spread ourselves about over the country, with an injunction to reunite at a given moment; in this fashion, ten by ten, we should excite no suspicion—we should pass unperceived. Yes, yes, thirty—that is a magic number. There are three tens—three, that divine number! And then, truly, a company of thirty men, when all together, will look rather imposing. Ah! stupid wretch that I am!’ continued D’Aragnan, ‘I want thirty horses. That is ruinous. Where the devil was my head when I forgot the horses? We cannot, however, think of striking such a blow without horses. Well, so be it, that sacrifice must be made; we can get the horses in the country—they are not bad, besides. But I forgot—petee! Three bands—that necessitates three leaders; there is the difficulty. Of the three commanders I have already one—that is myself;—yes, but the two others will of themselves cost almost as much money as all the rest of the troop. No; positively I must have but one lieutenant. In that case, then, I should reduce my troop to twenty men. I know very well that twenty men is but very little; but since with thirty I was determined not to seek to come to blows, I should do so more carefully still with twenty. Twenty—that is a round number; that, besides, reduces the number of the horses by ten, which is a consideration; and then, with a good lieutenant—Mordieux! what things patience and calculation are! Was I not going to embark with forty men, and I have now reduced them to twenty for an equal success? Ten thousand livres saved at one stroke, and more safety; that is well! Now, then, let us see; we have nothing to do but to find this lieutenant—let him be found, then; and after—That is not so easy; he must be brave and good, a second myself. Yes, but a lieutenant must have my secret, and as that secret is worth a million, and I shall only pay my man a thousand livres, fifteen hundred at the most, my man will sell the secret to Monk. Mordieux! no lieutenant. Besides, this man, were he as mute as a disciple of Pythagoras,—this man would be sure to have in the troop some favourite soldier, whom he would make his sergeant; the sergeant would penetrate the secret of the lieutenant, in case the latter should be honest and unwilling to sell it. Then the sergeant, less honest and less ambitious, will give up the whole for fifty thousand livres. Come, come! that is impossible. The lieutenant is impossible. But then I must have

of his fist upon the doors of the hostleries;—his memory, always active and present, brought back that youth which neither thirty years later his great heart nor his wrist of steel would have belied. What a rich nature was that of this man! He had all the passions, all the defects, all the weaknesses, and the spirit of contradiction familiar to his understanding changed all these imperfections into corresponding qualities. D’Aragnan, thanks to his ever active imagination, was afraid of a shadow, and ashamed of being afraid, he marched straight up to that shadow, and then became extravagant in his bravery, if the danger proved to be real. Thus everything in him was emotion, and therefore enjoyment. He loved the society of others, but never became tired of his own; and more than once, if he could have been heard when he was alone, he might have been seen laughing at the jokes he related to himself or the tricks his imagination created just five minutes before ennui might have been looked for. D’Aragnan was not perhaps so gay this time as he would have been with the prospect of finding some good friends at Calais, instead of joining the ten scamps there; melancholy, however, did not visit him more than once a day, and it was about five visits that he received from that sombre deity before he got sight of the sea at Boulogne, and then these visits were indeed but short. But when once D’Aragnan found himself near the field of action, all other feelings but that of confidence disappeared never to return. From Boulogne he followed the coast to Calais. Calais was the place of general rendezvous, and at Calais he had named to each of his recruits the hostelry of ‘Le Grande Monarque,’ where living was not extravagant, where sailors messed, and where men of the sword, with sheath of leather, be it understood, found lodging, table, food, and all the comforts of life, for thirty sous per diem. D’Aragnan proposed to himself to take them by surprise in flagrant delicto of wandering life, and to judge by the first appearance if he could count on them as trusty companions.

He arrived at Calais at half past four in the afternoon.

Chapter XXI

In which D'Artagnan Prepares to Travel



D'ARTAGNAN reflected to such good purpose during the night that his plan was settled by morning. 'This is it,' said he, sitting up in bed, supporting his elbow on his knee, and his chin in his hand;—'this is it. I shall seek out forty steady, firm men, recruited among people a little compromised, but having habits of discipline. I shall promise them five hundred lives for a month if they return; nothing if they do not return, or half for their kindred. As to food and lodging, that concerns the English, who have cattle in their pastures, bacon in their bacon-racks, fowls in their poultry-yards, and corn in their barns. I will present myself to General Monk with my little body of troops. He will receive me. I shall win his confidence, and take advantage of it, as soon as possible.'

But without going further, D'Artagnan shook his head and interrupted himself. 'No,' said he; 'I should not dare to relate this to Athos; the way is therefore not honourable. I must use violence,' continued he, — 'very certainly I must, but without compromising my loyalty. With forty men I will traverse the country as a partisan. But if I fall in with, not forty thousand English, as Planchet said, but purely and simply with four hundred, I shall be beaten. Supposing that among my forty warriors there should be found at least ten stupid ones—ten who will allow themselves to be killed one after the other, from mere folly? No; it is, in fact, impossible to find forty men to be depended upon—they do not exist. I must learn how to be contented with thirty. With ten men less I should have the right of avoiding any armed encounter, on account of the small number of my people; and if the encounter should take

‘Thank you,’ replied the musketeer, politely; after which the two partners reperused their deed.

‘That is perfect, monsieur,’ said Planchet; ‘and the late M. Coquenard, the first husband of Madame la Baronne du Vallon, could not have done it better.’

‘Do you find it so? Let us sign it then.’ And both affixed their signatures.

‘In this fashion,’ said D’Artagnan, ‘I shall be under obligations to no one.’

‘But I shall be under obligations to you,’ said Planchet.

‘No; for whatever store I set by it, Planchet, I may lose my skin yonder, and you will lose all. A propos—pestel—that makes me think of the principal, an indispensable clause. I shall write it:—“In case of M. d’Artagnan dying in this enterprise, liquidation will be considered made, and the Sieur Planchet will give quitance from that moment to the shade of Messire d’Artagnan for the twenty thousand livres paid by him into the hands of the said company.”’

This last clause made Planchet knit his brows a little, but when he saw the brilliant eye, the muscular hand, the supple and strong back of his associate, he regained his courage, and, without regret, he at once added another stroke to his signature. D’Artagnan did the same. Thus was drawn the first known company contract; perhaps such things have been abused a little since, both in form and principle.

‘Now,’ said Planchet, pouring out the last glass of Anjou wine for D’Artagnan,—‘now go to sleep, my dear master.’

‘No,’ replied D’Artagnan; ‘for the most difficult part now remains to be done, and I will think over that difficult part.’

‘Bah!’ said Planchet; ‘I have such great confidence in you, M. d’Artagnan, that I would not give my hundred thousand livres for ninety thousand livres down.’

‘And devil take me if I don’t think you are right!’ Upon which D’Artagnan took a candle and went up to his bedroom.

Chapter XXII

D’Artagnan Travels for the House of Planchet and Company



HE hostelry of ‘Le Grand Monarque’ was situated in a little street parallel to the port without looking out upon the port itself. Some lanes cut—as steps cut the two parallels of the ladder—the two great straight lines of the port and the street. By these lanes passengers came suddenly from the port into the street, or from the street on to the port. D’Artagnan, arrived at the port, took one of these lanes, and came out in front of the hostelry of ‘Le Grand Monarque.’ The moment was well chosen and might remind D’Artagnan of his start in life at the hostelry of the ‘Franc-Meurier’ at Meung. Some sailors who had been playing at dice had started a quarrel, and were threatening each other furiously. The host, hostess, and two lads were watching with anxiety the circle of these angry gamblers, from the midst of which war seemed ready to break forth, bristling with knives and hatchets. The play, nevertheless, was continued. A stone bench was occupied by two men, who appeared thence to watch the door; four tables, placed at the back of the common chamber, were occupied by eight other individuals. Neither the men at the door, nor those at the tables took any part in the play or the quarrel. D’Artagnan recognized his ten men in these cold, indifferent spectators. The quarrel went on increasing. Every passion has, like the sea, its tide which ascends and descends. Reaching the climax of passion, one sailor overturned the table and the money which was upon it. The table fell, and the money rolled about. In an instant all belonging to the hostelry threw themselves upon the stakes, and many a piece of silver

was picked up by people who stole away whilst the sailors were scuffling with each other.

The two men on the bench and the eight at the tables, although they seemed perfect strangers to each other, these ten men alone, we say, appeared to have agreed to remain impassible amidst the cries of fury and the chinking of money. Two only contented themselves with pushing with their feet combatants who came under their table. Two others, rather than take part in this disturbance, buried their hands in their pockets; and another two jumped upon the table they occupied, as people do to avoid being submerged by overflowing water.

‘Come, come,’ said D’Aragnan to himself, not having lost one of the details we have related, ‘this is a very fair gathering—circumspect, calm, accustomed to disturbance, acquainted with blows! Pestel! I have been lucky!’

All at once his attention was called to a particular part of the room. The two men who had pushed the strugglers with their feet, were assailed with abuse by the sailors, who had become reconciled. One of them, half drunk with passion, and quite drunk with beer, came, in a menacing manner, to demand of the shorter of these two sages by what right he had touched with his foot creatures of the good God, who were not dogs. And whilst putting this question, in order to make it more direct, he applied his great fist to the nose of D’Aragnan’s recruit.

This man became pale, without its being to be discerned whether his pallor arose from anger or fear; seeing which, the sailor concluded it was from fear, and raised his fist with the manifest intention of letting it fall upon the head of the stranger. But though the threatened man did not appear to move, he dealt the sailor such a severe blow in the stomach that he sent him rolling and howling to the other side of the room. At the same instant, rallied by the esprit de corps, all the comrades of the conquered man fell upon the conqueror.

The latter, with the same coolness of which he had given proof, without committing the imprudence of touching his weapons, took up a beer-pot with a pewter-lid, and knocked down two or three of his assailants; then, as he was about to yield to numbers, the seven other silent men at the tables, who had not yet stirred, perceived that their cause was at stake, and came to the rescue. At the same time, the two indifferent spectators at the door turned round with frowning bows, indicating their evident intention of taking the enemy in the rear, if the enemy did not cease their aggressions.

Hôtel de la Chevette; and the Sieur Planchet, grocer, residing in the Rue des Lombards, at the sign of the Pilon d’Or, it has been agreed as follows:—A company, with a capital of forty thousand livres, and formed for the purpose of carrying out an idea conceived by M. d’Aragnan, and the said Planchet approving of it in all points, will place twenty thousand livres in the hands of M. d’Aragnan. He will require neither repayment nor interest before the return of M. d’Aragnan from a journey he is about to take into England. On his part, M. d’Aragnan undertakes it to find twenty thousand livres, which he will join to the twenty thousand already laid down by the Sieur Planchet. He will employ the said sum of forty thousand livres according to his judgment in an undertaking which is described below. On the day when M. d’Aragnan shall have re-established, by whatever means, his majesty King Charles II upon the throne of England, he will pay into the hands of M. Planchet the sum of—’

‘The sum of a hundred and fifty thousand livres,’ said Planchet, innocently, perceiving that D’Aragnan hesitated.

‘Oh, the devil, no!’ said D’Aragnan, ‘the division cannot be made by half; that would not be just!’

‘And yet, monsieur, we each lay down half,’ objected Planchet, timidly.

‘Yes; but listen to this clause, my dear Planchet, and if you do not find it equitable in every respect when it is written, well, we can scratch it out again:—“Nevertheless, as M. d’Aragnan brings to the association, besides his capital of twenty thousand livres, his time, his idea, his industry, and his skin,—things which he appreciates strongly, particularly the last,—M. d’Aragnan will keep, of the three hundred thousand livres, two hundred thousand livres for himself, which will make his share two-thirds.”’

‘Very well,’ said Planchet.

‘Is it just?’ asked D’Aragnan.

‘Perfectly just, monsieur.’

‘And you will be contented with a hundred thousand livres?’

‘Pestel! I think so. A hundred thousand for twenty thousand!’

‘And in a month, understand.’

‘How, in a month?’

‘Yes, I only ask one month.’

‘Monsieur,’ said Planchet, generously, ‘I give you six weeks.’

said, "Such was the old age of M. d'Arragnan," and I shall hold a place in tales and even in history itself, Planchet. I am greedy of honour."

'Monsieur,' cried Planchet, 'when I think that it is here, in my home, in the midst of my sugar, my prunes, and my cinnamon, that this gigantic project is ripened, my shop seems a palace to me.'

'Beware, beware, Planchet! If the least report of this escapes, there is the Bastille for both of us. Beware, my friend, for this is a plot we are hatching. M. Monk is the ally of M. Mazarin—beware!'

'Monsieur, when a man has had the honour to belong to you, he knows nothing of fear; and when he has had the advantage of being bound up in interests with you, he holds his tongue.'

'Very well; that is more your affair than mine, seeing that in a week I shall be in England.'

'Depart, monsieur, depart—the sooner the better.'

'Is the money, then, ready?'

'It will be to-morrow; to-morrow you shall receive it from my own hands. Will you have gold or silver?'

'Gold; that is most convenient. But how are we going to arrange this? Let us see.'

'Oh, good Lord! in the simplest way possible. You shall give me a receipt, that is all.'

'No, no,' said D'Arragnan, warmly; 'we must preserve order in all things.'

'That is likewise my opinion; but with you, M. d'Arragnan—'

'And if I should die yonder—if I should be killed by a musket-ball—if I should burst from drinking beer?'

'Monsieur, I beg you to believe that in that case I should be so much afflicted at your death, that I should not think about the money.'

'Thank you, Planchet; but no matter. We shall, like two lawyers' clerks, draw up together an agreement, a sort of act, which may be called a deed of company.'

'Willingly, monsieur.'

'I know it is difficult to draw such a thing up, but we can try.'

'Let us try, then.' And Planchet went in search of pens, ink, and paper. D'Arragnan took the pen and wrote:—'Between Messire d'Arragnan, ex-lieutenant of the king's musketeers, at present residing in the Rue Tiquetonne,

The host, his helpers, and two watchmen who were passing, and who from the curiosity had penetrated too far into the room, were mixed up in the tumult and showered with blows. The Parisians hit like Cyclops, with an ensemble and a tactic delightful to behold. At length, obliged to beat a retreat before superior numbers, they formed an intrenchment behind the large table, which they raised by main force; whilst the two others, arming themselves each with a trestle, and using it like a great sledge-hammer, knocked down at a blow eight sailors upon whose heads they had brought their monstrous catapult in play. The floor was already strewn with wounded, and the room filled with cries and dust, when D'Arragnan, satisfied with the test, advanced, sword in hand, and striking with the pommel every head that came in his way, he uttered a vigorous hola! which put an instantaneous end to the conflict. A great back-flood directly took place from the centre to the sides of the room, so that D'Arragnan found himself isolated and dominant.

'What is this all about?' then demanded he of the assembly, with the majestic tone of Neptune pronouncing the Quos ego.

At the very instant, at the first sound of his voice, to carry on the Virgilian metaphor, D'Arragnan's recruits, recognizing each his sovereign lord, discontinued their plank-fighting and trestle blows. On their side, the sailors, seeing that long naked sword, that martial air, and the agile arm which came to the rescue of their enemies, in the person of a man who seemed accustomed to command, the sailors picked up their wounded and their pitchers. The Parisians wiped their brows, and viewed their leader with respect. D'Arragnan was loaded with thanks by the host of 'Le Grand Monarque.' He received them like a man who knows that nothing is being offered that does not belong to him, and then said he would go and walk upon the port till supper was ready. Immediately each of the recruits, who understood the summons, took his hat, brushed the dust off his clothes, and followed D'Arragnan. But D'Arragnan, whilst walking and observing, took care not to stop; he directed his course towards the downs, and the ten men—surprised at finding themselves going in the track of each other, uneasy at seeing on their right, on their left, and behind them, companions upon whom they had not reckoned—followed him, casting furtive glances at each other. It was not till he had arrived at the hollow part of the deepest down that D'Arragnan, smiling to see them outdone, turned towards them, making a friendly sign with his hand.

'Eh! come, come, gentlemen,' said he, 'let us not devour each other; you are made to live together, to understand each other in all respects, and not to devour one another.'

Instantly all hesitation ceased; the men breathed as if they had been taken out of a coffin, and examined each other complacently. After this examination they turned their eyes towards their leader, who had long been acquainted with the art of speaking to men of that class, and who improvised the following little speech, pronounced with an energy truly Gascon:

'Gentlemen, you all know who I am. I have engaged you from knowing you to be brave, and willing to associate you with me in a glorious enterprise. Imagine that in labouring for me you labour for the king. I only warn you that if you allow anything of this supposition to appear, I shall be forced to crack your skulls immediately, in the manner most convenient to me. You are not ignorant, gentlemen, that state secrets are like a mortal poison: as long as that poison is in its box and the box is closed, it is not injurious; out of the box, it kills. Now draw near, and you shall know as much of this secret as I am able to tell you.' All drew close to him with an expression of curiosity. 'Approach,' continued D'Artagnan, 'and let not the bird which passes over our heads, the rabbit which sports on the downs, the fish which bounds from the waters, hear us. Our business is to learn and to report to monsieur le surintendant of the finances to what extent English smuggling is injurious to the French merchants. I shall enter every place, and see everything. We are poor Picard fishermen, thrown upon the coast by a storm. It is certain that we must sell fish, neither more nor less, like true fishermen. Only people might guess who we are, and might molest us; it is therefore necessary that we should be in a condition to defend ourselves. And this is why I have selected men of spirit and courage. We shall lead a steady life, and not incur much danger, seeing that we have behind us a powerful protector, thanks to whom no embarrassment is possible. One thing alone puzzles me; but I hope that after a short explanation, you will relieve me from that difficulty. The thing which puzzles me is taking with me a crew of stupid fishermen, which crew will annoy me immensely, whilst if, by chance, there were among you any who have seen the sea—'

'Oh! don't let that trouble you,' said one of the recruits; 'I was a prisoner among the pirates of Tunis three years, and can manoeuvre a boat like an admiral.'

'In the first place, I shall set a ransom on him.'

'Of how much?'

'Peste! a fellow like that must be well worth a hundred thousand crowns.'

'Yes, yes!'

'You see, then—in the first place, a ransom of a hundred thousand crowns.'

'Or else—'

'Or else, what is much better, I deliver him up to King Charles, who, having no longer either a general or an army to fear, nor a diplomatist to trick him, will restore himself, and when once restored, will pay down to me the hundred thousand crowns in question. That is the idea I have formed; what do you say to it, Planchet?'

'Magnificent, monsieur!' cried Planchet, trembling with emotion. 'How did you conceive that idea?'

'It came to me one morning on the banks of the Loire, whilst our beloved king, Louis XIV, was pretending to weep upon the hand of Mademoiselle de Mancini.'

'Monsieur, I declare the idea is sublime. But—'

'Ah! is there a but?'

'Permit me! But this is a little like the skin of that fine bear—you know—that they were about to sell, but which it was necessary to take from the back of the living bear. Now, to take M. Monk, there will be a bit of a scuffle, I should think.'

'No doubt; but as I shall raise an army to—'

'Yes, yes—I understand, *parbleu!*—a *coup-de-main*. Yes, then, monsieur, you will triumph, for no one equals you in such sorts of encounters.'

'I certainly am lucky in them,' said D'Artagnan, with a proud simplicity. 'You know that if for this affair I had my dear Athos, my brave Portos, and my cunning Aramis, the business would be settled; but they are all lost, as it appears, and nobody knows where to find them. I will do it, then, alone. Now, do you find the business good, and the investment advantageous?'

'Too much so—too much so.'

'How can that be?'

'Because fine things never reach the expected point.'

'This is infallible, Planchet, and the proof is that I undertake it. It will be for you a tolerably pretty gain, and for me a very interesting stroke. It will be

‘Bravo! You know then, in that case—for you have not learnt mathematics and philosophy without a little history—that after this Cromwell so great, there came one who was very little.’

‘Yes; he was named Richard, and he as done as you have, M. d’Arragnan—he has tendered his resignation.’

‘Very well said—very well! After the great man who is dead, after the little one who tendered his resignation, there came a third. This one is named Monk; he is an able general, considering he has never fought a battle; he is a skilful diplomatist, considering that he never speaks in public, and that having to say “good-day” to a man, he meditates twelve hours, and ends by saying “good night;” which makes people exclaim “miracle!” seeing that it falls out correctly.’

‘That is rather strong,’ said Planchet; ‘but I know another political man who resembles him very much.’

‘M. Mazarin you mean?’

‘Himself.’

‘You are right, Planchet; only M. Mazarin does not aspire to the throne of France; and that changes everything. Do you see? Well, this M. Monk, who has England ready-roasted in his plate, and who is already opening his mouth to swallow it—this M. Monk, who says to the people of Charles II, and to Charles II himself, “Nescio vos”—’

‘I don’t understand English,’ said Planchet.

‘Yes, but I understand it,’ said D’Arragnan. “‘Nescio vos’ means “I do not know you.” This M. Monk, the most important man in England, when he shall have swallowed it—’

‘Well?’ asked Planchet.

‘Well, my friend, I shall go over yonder, and with my forty men I shall carry him off, pack him up, and bring him into France, where two modes of proceeding present themselves to my dazzled eyes.’

‘Oh! and to mine too,’ cried Planchet, transported with enthusiasm. ‘We will put him in a cage and show him for money.’

‘Well, Planchet, that is a third plan, of which I had not thought.’

‘Do you think it a good one?’

‘Yes, certainly; but I think mine better.’

‘Let us see yours, then.’

‘See,’ said D’Arragnan, ‘what an admirable thing chance is!’ D’Arragnan pronounced these words with an indefinable tone of feigned bonhomie, for he knew very well that the victim of the pirates was an old corsair, and had engaged him in consequence of that knowledge. But D’Arragnan never said more than there was need to say, in order to leave people in doubt. He paid himself with the explanation, and welcomed the effect, without appearing to be preoccupied with the cause.

‘And I,’ said a second, ‘I, by chance, had an uncle who directed the works of the port of La Rochelle. When quite a child, I played about the boats, and I know how to handle an oar or a sail as well as the best Ponantais sailor.’ The latter did not lie much more than the first, for he had rowed on board his majesty’s galleys six years, at Ciotat. Two others were more frank: they confessed honestly that they had served on board a vessel as soldiers as punishment, and did not blush for it. D’Arragnan found himself, then, the leader of ten men of war and four sailors, having at once an land army and a sea force, which would have carried the pride of Planchet to its height, if Planchet had known the details.

Nothing was now left but arranging the general orders, and D’Arragnan gave them with precision. He enjoined his men to be ready to set out for the Hague, some following the coast which leads to Breskens, others the road to Antwerp. The rendezvous was given, by calculating each day’s march, a fortnight from that time, upon the chief place at the Hague. D’Arragnan recommended his men to go in couples, as they liked best, from sympathy. He himself selected from among those with the least disreputable look, two guards whom he had formerly known, and whose only faults were being drunkards and gamblers. These men had not entirely lost all ideas of civilization, and under proper garments their hearts would beat again. D’Arragnan, not to create any jealousy with the others, made the rest go forward. He kept his two selected ones, clothed them from his own wardrobe, and set out with them.

It was to these two, whom he seemed to honour with an absolute confidence, that D’Arragnan imparted a false secret, destined to secure the success of the expedition. He confessed to them that the object was not to learn to what extent French merchants were injured by English smuggling, but to learn how far French smuggling could annoy English trade. These men appeared convinced; they were effectively so. D’Arragnan was quite sure that at the first

debauch, when thoroughly drunk, one of the two would divulge the secret to the whole band. His game appeared infallible.

A fortnight after all we have said had taken place at Calais, the whole troop assembled at the Hague.

Then D'Artagnan perceived that all his men, with remarkable intelligence, had already travestied themselves into sailors, more or less ill-treated by the sea. D'Artagnan left them to sleep in a den in Newkerke street, whilst he lodged comfortably upon the Grand Canal. He learned that the king of England had come back to his old ally, William II of Nassau, stadtholder of Holland. He learned also that the refusal of Louis XIV had a little cooled the protection afforded him up to that time, and in consequence he had gone to reside in a little village house at Scheveningen, situated in the downs, on the sea-shore, about a league from the Hague.

There, it was said, the unfortunate banished king consoled himself in his exile, by looking, with the melancholy peculiar to the princes of his race, at that immense North Sea, which separated him from his England, as it had formerly separated Mary Stuart from France. There, behind the trees of the beautiful wood of Scheveningen, on the fine sand upon which grows the golden broom of the down, Charles II vegetated as it did, more unfortunate, for he had life and thought, and he hoped and despaired by turns.

D'Artagnan went once as far as Scheveningen, in order to be certain that all was true that was said of the king. He beheld Charles II, pensive and alone, coming out of a little door opening into the wood, and walking on the beach in the setting sun, without even attracting the attention of the fishermen, who, on their return in the evening, drew, like the ancient mariners of the Archipelago, their barks up upon the sand of the shore.

D'Artagnan recognized the king; he saw him fix his melancholy look upon the immense extent of the waters, and absorb upon his pale countenance the red rays of the sun already cut by the black line of the horizon. Then Charles returned to his isolated abode, always alone, slow and sad, amusing himself with making the friable and moving sand creak beneath his feet.

That very evening D'Artagnan hired for a thousand livres a fishing-boat worth four thousand. He paid a thousand livres down, and deposited the three thousand with a Burgomaster, after which he brought on board, without their being seen, the six men who formed his land army; and with the rising tide, at

You should know that, Planchet, you who commanded the Parisians the day on which they ought to have fought against the musketeers, and who so well calculated marches and countermarches, that you never left the Palais Royal.'

Planchet could not help laughing. 'It is plain,' replied he, 'that if your forty men conceal themselves, and are not unskilful, they may hope not to be beaten: but you propose obtaining some result, do you not?'

'No doubt. This, then, in my opinion, is the plan to be proceeded upon in order quickly to replace his majesty Charles II on his throne.'

'Good!' said Planchet, increasing his attention; 'let us see your plan. But in the first place it seems to me we are forgetting something.'

'What is that?'

'We have set aside the nation, which prefers singing merry songs to psalms, and the army, which we will not fight; but the parliament remains, and that seldom sings.'

'Nor does it fight. How is it, Planchet, that an intelligent man like yourself should take any heed of a set of brawlers who call themselves Rumps and Barebones? The parliament does not trouble me at all, Planchet.'

'As soon as it ceases to trouble you, monsieur, let us pass on.'

'Yes, and arrive at the result. You remember Cromwell, Planchet?'

'I have heard a great deal of talk about him.'

'He was a rough soldier.'

'And a terrible eater, moreover.'

'What do you mean by that?'

'Why, at one gulp he swallowed all England.'

'Well, Planchet, the evening before the day on which he swallowed England, if any one had swallowed M. Cromwell?'

'Oh, monsieur, it is one of the axioms of mathematics that the container must be greater than the contained.'

'Very well! That is our affair, Planchet.'

'But M. Cromwell is dead, and his container is now the tomb.'

'My dear Planchet, I see with pleasure that you have not only become a mathematician, but a philosopher.'

'Monsieur, in my grocery business I use much printed paper, and that instructs me.'